

41 4 Hatherley Road. Kew Gardens. 23 v. 19

Dear Sir:

Thank you very much for your letter: I
wondered very much to come to your lecture
but I am always engaged at that time -
I look forward to reading them when published.

I am afraid I must express myself very
badly: but you will admit it is hard!

Of course I admit that words are physical
occurrences: but that is not what I mean,
by a word. There is the word tiger and the thing
tiger: both physical occurrences (so called!). But
if analysed both these occurrences are reducible
to terms of pressure + the effect of the pressure - which
may be an electric phenomenon. All we know is
that our sense 'work' by pressure: what presses
is at present unknown & seems unknowable.

Starting then with the knowledge that something
presses (i.e. light, sound, touch etc) we know that
we construct by arbitrary but convenient
selection what we call the idea of a thing which is
the only thing we know or can know.

What we call tiger is as obvious and as
unreal as a rainbow & for the same reason
i.e. because it is an epiphenomenon. This may
expose me to the retort that everything must be
an epiphenomenon: I can't help thinking that
everything is potentially an epiphenomenon, just as
every son is potentially a father.

It is our fond belief that ^{what} we see is real: so (2)
it is: but it is real not because it is, but
because we see it. And when we think of
people with D.T. ~~we~~ do not realize that if they
suffer from an affliction it is because their
delirium is incoherent, whereas in this world
it is advisable to suffer only from delirium coherent.

This delirium coherent is real: you will
probably grant that mathematics is so too.
And my aim is to show that all knowledge is
not only similar to but identical with mathematical
knowledge: that it is hard to say what a point
is for the same reason & in the same way as it
is hard to say what a tiger is. That two tigers
are just as difficult to negotiate as two points
and for the same reason. That if hands are
points, verbs are points in motion: that
adjectives ~~are~~ produce the effect in calculations
and so on.

For instance on p 173 of your Intro. Nat. Phil.
you discuss the difference between Scott & Arthur
& Waverley. The difference seems to me exactly
the same as that between two infinite series

$$\begin{aligned}\text{Scott} &= x^1. x^2. x^3. \dots n \dots \\ \text{A. \& W.} &= x^1. x^2. x^3. x^4. \dots n \dots\end{aligned}$$

You say on p 164 that the fundamental
meaning of the word existence is that "argument
satisfying ϕx exist." If I understand that
rightly, that exactly defines my position.

You know that I have such a respect for your

knowing that I am not deceived by your saying
 that you cannot pretend to have a considerable
 knowledge of languages: on the other hand, I
 am not at all impressed by your saying you
^{have} ~~read~~ read a good deal about language. If you
 had said thought a good deal — that is quite
 another matter. But isn't it certain that the
 science of language is hopelessly at sea? One
 has only to consider the hopeless mess western
 grammarians have made of Japanese. I am
 assured by experts that the Japanese themselves
 have never written their own grammar. I
 doubt it, but am not yet in a position to
 judge. But even the elementary knowledge I
 have of Arabic & Japanese grammar has given
 me an insight into the limitations of any
 grammatical ideas based only on our languages.

A number of examples that you discuss
 quite seriously (if I understand you rightly)
 as logical problems, simply don't exist in
 other idioms. I should like to know whether
 your discussion of THE and A has any meaning
 at all for a man brought up in Sweden
 (where the ideas are quite logically expressed) or in
 Japan (where there is no article at all). There
 are always three potential uses of a name:

Tiger which may be thought of as a circle
 A Tiger is any one point on the circle
 The Tiger is that one point I mean on the circle

These are the ideas: and the way they are
 expressed is of as secondary importance as the
 difference between the figure 4 and the Arabic ٤

On p 164. You discuss the little problem
 Men exist
 Men are numerous } $\therefore$ Socrates ...

But it seems to me that this has nothing to do with logic: it is due to an idiomatic use of language: in many other languages the first men would clearly express 'all men' and the second men would be expressed by a word expressing 'collection'. One might as well play tricks with the fact that 0 stands for 5 in Arabic.

Again on pp 156/157 you discuss
 Lightning --- Thunder.
 Napoleon St Helena.

If we deal with them by the circle method
 we have lightning-ness
 a flash i.e. any flash, one
 the flash i.e. the one I mean.

Napoleon firstishness
 a Napoleon I.
 the Napoleon I.

And I can say in each case:
 lightning is followed by thunder
 a flash
 the flash

Napoleon the firstishness died at St H.
 a Napoleon I
 the

We are as certain of all these statements as we are that a line moving in a plane envelops

a plane curve. The examples surely are (5
only of commercial interest.

Lastly on p 172 you make the astonishing
statement that in Socrates is a man, the
is expresses identity. I admit that the
English phrasing is extraordinarily difficult to
explain: still more difficult to defend. But it
is of no use deceiving ourselves by thinking that
our language is anything but what it is. The
difficulty would not be apparent in the languages
that don't use IS - or only use the verb in the
past tense. The logical meaning seems to me
to be clear: I have a circle (or idea) MAN.
One of the points - (not any point as would
seem to be suggested by A man) - a definite point
on that circle is Socrates - the man I mean.
It is of course fairly obvious that one of the
concurrent uses of THE in English is to turn
the noun that follows it into a proper name,
much as it acts in the phrase The O'Connor.

I have written at great length: but I am
sure I may say without your misunderstanding
me that it is very hard for anyone quite unknown
to get his ideas considered at all by anyone competent
to weigh them. I think (you will forgive my
putting it this way!) I think I shall give up
any idea of publishing, if you out and out condemn
my ideas. But my ambition is to ^{hear} ~~have~~ you say
there is something in them: and ^{then} to see them
published so that competent people may, if
there is anything in them, set to work & develop

* What is latent in them. I am already 40 years
old and still have to make my living, so that I
cannot hope to reach any adquate mastery
of languages & mathematics. But I feel
confident that in that combination will
be found many surprising discoveries—

Please accept my very sincere thanks.

Yours faithfully
W.O. Rignstocke.